

Psalms 1

The Two Ways

Blessed is the man that walketh not in the counsel of the ungodly
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Blessed is the man that walketh not in the counsel of the ungodly, nor standeth in the way of sinners, nor sitteth in the seat of the scornful.*
- 2 *But his delight is in the law of the Lord; and in his law doth he meditate day and night.*
- 3 *And he shall be like a tree planted by the rivers of water, that bringeth forth his fruit in his season; his leaf also shall not wither; and whatsoever he doeth shall prosper.*
- 4 *The ungodly are not so: but are like the chaff which the wind driveth away.*
- 5 *Therefore the ungodly shall not stand in the judgment, nor sinners in the congregation of the righteous.*
- 6 *For the Lord knoweth the way of the righteous: but the way of the ungodly shall perish.*

2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 1 is the gateway psalm of the entire Psalter. It was placed first (though not necessarily written first) as a wisdom “gate”: before worshipers sing, pray, or lament, they are shown two ways of life and two destinies. It belongs with the wisdom tradition (alongside Proverbs) and anticipates Jesus’ teaching on the two paths (Matthew 7:13–14). Matthew Henry observes that the collector of the psalms (often associated with Ezra’s era) put this poem first so people would choose the right way of blessedness before offering devotion. The psalm names no author and no single historical crisis; its setting is every generation’s daily choice of counsel, company, and what the heart delights in.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1

The psalm opens with a beatitude—“Blessed” (truly happy under God’s favor). The blessed life is described first negatively: three downward steps (walk, stand, sit) with three kinds of people (ungodly, sinners, scornful). Henry and MacArthur-style notes both stress progressive entanglement: bad counsel becomes a settled path, then a fixed seat of mockery. The righteous refuse that drift. “Counsel” is not only formal advice—it is the worldview that shapes decisions.

Verse 2

The positive center of the psalm: delight in the law (torah—instruction) of the Lord, and meditation day and night. Meditation here is not empty mindfulness but ongoing conversation with God’s Word—turning it over, applying it, loving it. Henry: no time is amiss for regard to the Word as rule and comfort. This is the alternative to the counsel of the ungodly: not mere rule-keeping, but joy-driven attention to Scripture.

Verse 3

Image of the rooted life: a tree planted by rivers of water—deliberately placed, not self-sown (MacArthur-style emphasis on God’s transplanting grace). Fruit comes “in his season” (not always instantly); leaf does not wither under heat; “whatsoever he doeth shall prosper” is covenantal thriving—often spiritual and enduring, not a blank check for ease. Parallel themes appear in Jeremiah 17:7–8.

Verse 4

Sharp contrast: “The ungodly are not so.” Instead of a planted tree, they are chaff—the light husk separated from grain and driven by the wind. Empty of substance, unstable, moved by every pressure. What looks successful for a moment has no root.

Verse 5

Outcome of the chaff-life: they will not stand in the judgment, nor have a place in the congregation of the righteous. Henry warns that those who make themselves chaff will be found chaff when God’s winnowing comes—yet also holds out mercy for the sinner who turns and enters the company of the righteous by grace.

Verse 6

The final verdict belongs to the Lord. He “knoweth” the way of the righteous—watches, owns, shepherds it. The way of the ungodly shall perish. Two ways, two ends; the difference is not first social status but relationship to God’s Word and God’s knowledge of a life.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Taken as a whole, Psalm 1 teaches that there are only two ways—not a third neutral path. The blessed person is defined by refusal of ungodly influence (v. 1), delight-filled meditation on God’s instruction (v. 2), and rooted fruitfulness (v. 3). The ungodly lack that root (v. 4) and will not endure judgment or the assembly of the righteous (v. 5). Verse 6 grounds both destinies in the Lord’s knowing and the perishing of the wicked way. The psalm is less a tip for success than a map of life under God: what you listen to, what you love, and where you are planted determine who you become.

Application for life today.

Today the “counsel of the ungodly” often arrives as feeds, group chats, workplace cynicism, and entertainment that quietly catechize the heart. Psalm 1 asks whose voice you walk with before you ask what you believe. Delight in Scripture will not grow if the Word is only crisis medicine; trees drink continually. Fruit comes in season: faithfulness may look quiet before it looks impressive. When culture rewards the scoffing seat, this psalm redefines success—known by the Lord, rooted in His Word, useful when heat comes. Practical steps: choose one unhurried daily slot in Scripture; audit one influence that pulls toward scorn; ask whether your closest counsel makes holiness more thinkable.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where do you most often absorb “counsel” this week (people, media, habits)—and does it push you toward delight in God’s Word or toward the seat of the scornful?

2. What would “meditating day and night” look like in your actual schedule—not as guilt, but as one concrete change you could plant by the water this week?

3. When life feels dry or windy, do you respond more like a rooted tree or like chaff? What truth from Psalm 1 do you need to hold onto right now?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, Psalm 1 (public domain; themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with John MacArthur Study Bible / MacArthur teaching on Psalm 1 (two ways; planted tree; chaff; Lord knows the righteous)—paraphrased, not quoted. Scripture: King James Version (public domain).